

7.2 Firewalls

Basically, you need a firewall to protect your computer against Trojans, spyware, worms and other known and unknown threats. A firewall prevents unauthorised or malicious applications from reaching your computer. A good personal firewall should enable even inexperienced users to customise and fine-tune security policies. ('Security policies' refers to, for example, what programs or types of traffic to block, and what to do when something bad seems to be happening.)

7.2.1 Sygate Personal Firewall (SPF)

SPF claims to be the easiest-to-use PC firewall. It's free for personal home use, as of now.



With SPF in place, you'll need to get used to warnings like this one!

Our Experience

First off, after installing and running SPF, you'll see some weird messages that may confuse you. Remember that every single outbound and incoming connection—many of which you may not be aware of—are monitored by SPF. It sits in the system tray, and monitors everything. Double-clicking the icon brings up the console, where you can manage everything about your connection, be it a LAN, a dial-up connection, or whatever else.

The console lists all the programs that have requested connection service. You can choose to allow, ask, block or terminate any of these—in short, meaning full control. The console can be as detailed or as sparse as you wish.

There's a continuous moving graph that shows how much traffic is moving through your connection, and how much of it is being blocked by SPF. Remember all the times when you see activity on your connection, and you don't know where it's coming from? With the firewall in place, all malicious traffic is blocked.